Understanding Hymn Harmony

Triads, inversions, dominant sevenths and convincing cadences.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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1. Build chords from the key

Find major and minor triads without memorising hand shapes.

Build chords from the key

Build a triad from a root, third and fifth. C-E-G is major; C-E-flat-G is minor because the third is lower. A similar finger shape can make a different quality on another root, so name the notes and listen. Practise C, F, G, D and B-flat major, then A, D and E minor.

Practise · Major becomes minor

Only the middle note changes. Listen to the colour.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left-hand triads

Use a comfortable 5-3-1 shape; release between chords.

Listen and check

Name the root, third and fifth before each chord. Can you change major to minor without moving the root or fifth?

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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2. Choose the nearest inversion

Keep common tones and reduce unnecessary jumps.

Choose the nearest inversion

A chord keeps its identity when a different chord tone sits at the bottom. Choose inversions that leave shared notes near one another. C-E-G can move to C-F-A by moving two fingers a small distance. Look at each voice as a little melody. Do not squeeze the hand into a shape that hurts.

Practise · C-F-G-C in a small space

Keep the common C for F. Move the other notes smoothly.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left-hand inversions

Prepare the whole next chord silently before sounding it.

Listen and check

Play just the top notes of the chords and listen to their line. Then restore the other notes without making the top line disappear.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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3. I, IV, V and vi

Understand the jobs of the most useful hymn chords.

I, IV, V and vi

Roman numerals name chords by their position in a key. In C, I is C major, IV is F, V is G and vi is A minor. Uppercase means major here; lowercase means minor. Learn the sound of leaving home and returning, not just the symbols. The same functions work in G: G, C, D and E minor.

Practise · C-major journey

Say I, vi, IV, V while playing the left-hand chords.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · G-major journey

Keep the notes close: G, E minor, C, D.

Listen and check

Hum the bass line and identify the moment that sounds like a return home. Try the progression from memory before looking at the notation again.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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4. The dominant seventh

Hear tension resolve without playing a large chord.

The dominant seventh

Add F to G-B-D and you have G7. In C major, B often rises to C while F falls to E. You can hear this pull using only two notes. A pianist may omit a doubled note or the fifth to make the chord comfortable. Learn the resolution before adding a full four-note shape.

Practise · Two notes show the resolution

Hear B move up and F move down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A compact G7

Left hand: the fifth D is omitted. Keep the movement small.

Listen and check

Play the seventh chord, pause, and sing the home note you expect next. Then play the resolution and compare.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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5. Recognise musical punctuation
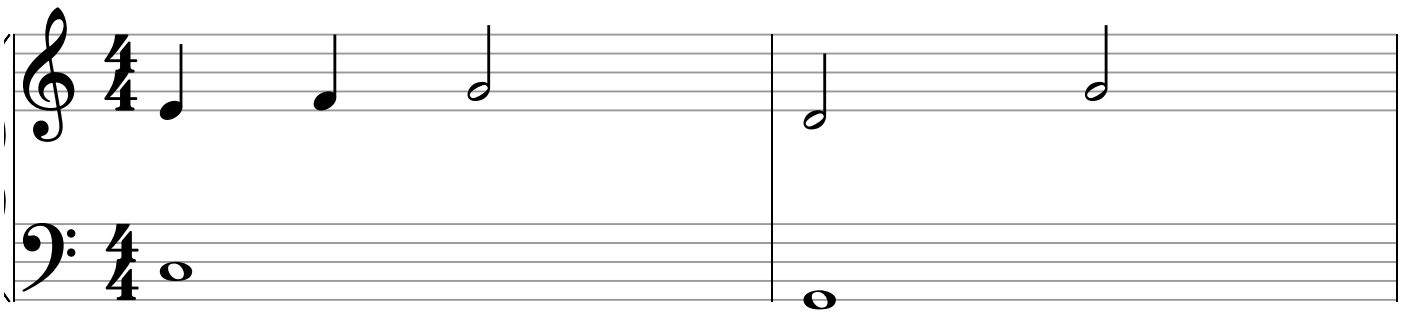
Choose a convincing pause or ending.

Recognise musical punctuation

A cadence is a harmonic punctuation mark. V-I sounds like an arrival, while a phrase ending on V often sounds unfinished. IV-I gives another familiar hymn ending. Keep the pulse through the cadence; slowing every time can break the musical sentence. Save a deliberate final broadening for a chosen ending.

Practise · Question and answer

The first phrase stops on G; the second comes home to C.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Amen cadence

Listen for IV-I: F major to C major.

Listen and check

Which phrase could finish the hymn and which invites another phrase? Try identifying a cadence in Rock of Ages before reading the accompaniment.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

6. Rock of Ages: connected chord shapes

Read each left-hand chord as a whole shape. Keep common tones and count the three-beat bars.
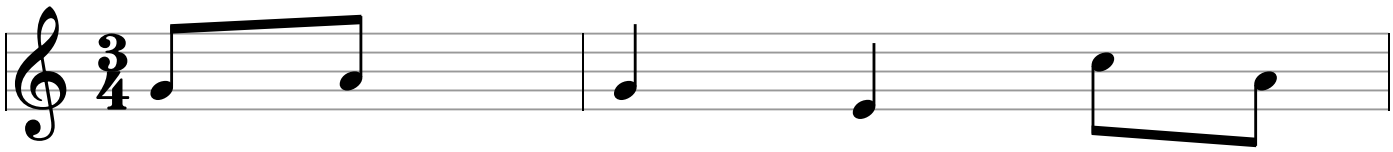
What to listen for

Read each left-hand chord as a whole shape. Keep common tones and count the three-beat bars.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Read each left-hand chord as a whole shape. Keep common tones and count the three-beat bars.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Read each left-hand chord as a whole shape. Keep common tones and count the three-beat bars.

Practise · Rock of Ages: connected chord shapes

Read each left-hand chord as a whole shape. Keep common tones and count the three-beat bars.

Your musical check

Name the chord roots and listen for the final return to C.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

7. When I Survey: harmonic punctuation

Listen for the phrases that end at home and those that invite another phrase.

What to listen for

Listen for the phrases that end at home and those that invite another phrase.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Listen for the phrases that end at home and those that invite another phrase.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Listen for the phrases that end at home and those that invite another phrase.

Practise · When I Survey: harmonic punctuation

Listen for the phrases that end at home and those that invite another phrase.

Your musical check

Play only the last two chords of each phrase and describe their effect.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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8. Take My Life and Let It Be

Keep the melody clear above compact chord inversions. Show the cadence without an unplanned pause.

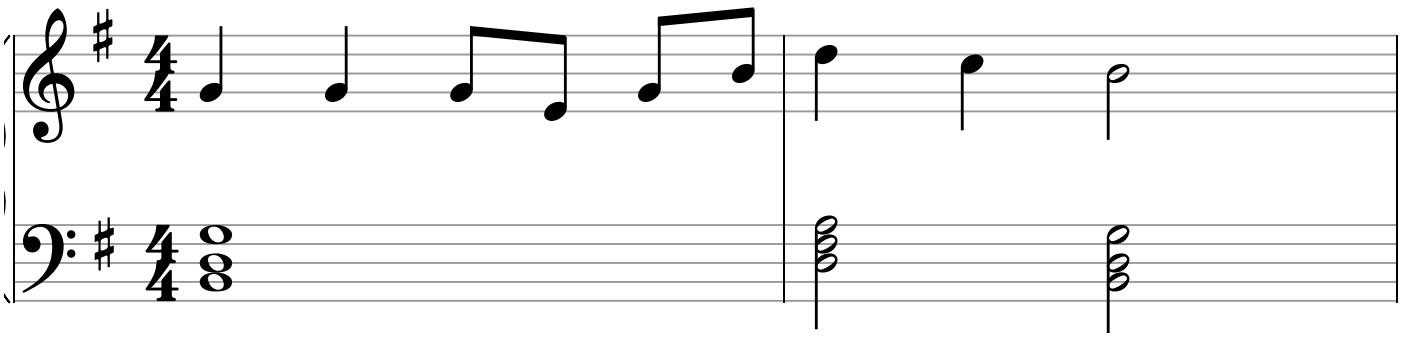
Prepare your recital

Keep the melody clear above compact chord inversions. Show the cadence without an unplanned pause.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Take My Life and Let It Be

Keep the melody clear above compact chord inversions. Show the cadence without an unplanned pause.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Keep the melody clear above compact chord inversions. Show the cadence without an unplanned pause.

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9. When I Survey the Wondrous Cross

Connect compact chord shapes, hear the cadence and keep the tune clear above the supporting harmony.

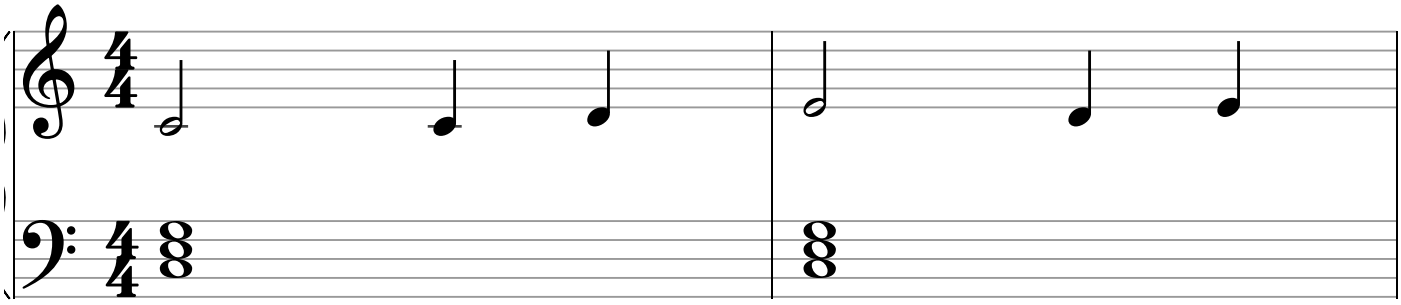
Prepare your recital

Connect compact chord shapes, hear the cadence and keep the tune clear above the supporting harmony.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: When I Survey the Wondrous Cross

Connect compact chord shapes, hear the cadence and keep the tune clear above the supporting harmony.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Connect compact chord shapes, hear the cadence and keep the tune clear above the supporting harmony.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Find major and minor triads without memorising hand shapes.
- ☐ Keep common tones and reduce unnecessary jumps.
- ☐ Understand the jobs of the most useful hymn chords.
- ☐ Hear tension resolve without playing a large chord.
- ☐ Choose a convincing pause or ending.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, a clear melody, steady pulse and comfortable movement.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
